

AAK - BASCO DURACOAT AWARDS OF EXCELLENCE IN ARCHITECTURE 2026

The **AAK - Basco DuraCoat Awards of Excellence in Architecture** hosted by the Architects Chapter, celebrate outstanding architectural achievements, recognizing Architects and project teams for innovation, creativity and excellence. The Awards aim to inspire architectural brilliance, foster professional pride, set industry benchmarks, encourage continuous improvement and honor the visionary individuals and projects shaping Kenya's architectural landscape.

Eligibility:

The submitted architectural projects are to have been built and completed within the **last five (5) years (2020 - 2025) in Kenya**, by members of the following associations:

1. The Architectural Association of Kenya (AAK)
2. Rwanda Institute of Architects (RIA)
3. Uganda Society of Architects (USA)
4. Architectural Association of Tanzania (AAT)

Submission Categories:

1. Best Africa (Re)presentation:

Entries in this category should demonstrate a meaningful and contemporary interpretation of African cultural identity. Submissions are expected to draw inspiration from local ways of life, tradition and culture, materials, artefacts, patterns, and environmental knowledge systems. Projects must articulate how these references have informed the design approach, resulting in architecture that resonates with regional relevance and expresses African heritage in a clear and intentional manner.

2. Best Commercial Project:

This category recognizes commercial developments that excel in functionality, spatial organization, user experience and contextual integration. Submissions must clearly demonstrate how the design supports commercial operations, enhances productivity or customer engagement, and responds sensitively to its physical and socio-economic setting. Consideration is given to environmental performance, material strategy & the project's overall contribution to its urban & natural environment.

3. Best Empowerment and Social Equity Through Design:

Submissions must illustrate how architectural design has directly enhanced **dignity, accessibility, inclusion** and livelihood opportunities for underserved or marginalized communities. Projects should highlight built-form solutions that improve participation, safety, equity and long-term community resilience. Emphasis is placed on tangible design interventions - spatial, structural, material, or environmental - that uplift vulnerable populations and support social transformation.

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4. Best Hospitality Project:

This category recognizes hotels, lodges, resorts and other guest - focused environments that deliver exceptional spatial quality, comfort and place-specific experience. Submissions should highlight how the design integrates with its landscape or urban setting, enhances ambience, and supports intuitive movement and relaxation. Priority is given to thoughtful material choices, environmental responsiveness, and the ability to create memorable, context-driven hospitality environments.

5. Best Institutional Project:

This category recognizes institutional projects - including educational facilities, healthcare centers, government buildings, cultural institutions, and community facilities - that excel in functionality, spatial organization, user experience, and contextual integration. Submissions must clearly demonstrate how the design serves institutional operations, enhances accessibility and inclusivity for diverse user groups, and responds sensitively to its physical and socio-economic setting. Consideration is given to environmental performance, material strategy, durability for public use, and the project's overall contribution to its urban and natural environment.

6. Best Religious/ Monumental Project:

Entries should exemplify architecture that carries symbolic, spiritual, or cultural significance. This includes churches, mosques, temples, meditation centers and monumental civic structures. Submissions are expected to show how form, materiality, procession, light and spatial organization work together to evoke meaning, support ritual practices and serve the surrounding community with dignity and clarity.

7. Best Interior Environment:

Submissions in this category must demonstrate refined and innovative interior design that enhances the function, atmosphere and comfort of indoor spaces. Projects should clearly illustrate effective spatial planning, material selection, lighting strategies, furniture integration, ventilation considerations and overall aesthetic harmony. The interior environment must show a coherent design language that elevates user experience.

8. Best Residential Project:

This category recognizes exemplary residential design - single family homes, multi-unit housing, or residential developments - that successfully combine aesthetics, functionality, climatic responsiveness, & contextual harmony. Submissions should highlight thoughtful spatial organization, material interplay, relationship to landscape, and overall enhancement of everyday living quality.

9. Best Student Project

Submissions must be conceptual work produced by students enrolled in accredited architecture programs. Projects should demonstrate strong conceptual grounding, clear articulation of design principles, contextual awareness, sustainability considerations, and high-quality presentation. The



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category values originality, thoughtful problem-solving, and the ability to translate complex ideas into coherent architectural propositions.

Evaluation Criteria:

1. Design; Innovation Technologies, Originality and Creativity – 45%
2. Contextual Appropriateness; Cultural, Environmental, Physical, Social – 20%
3. Sustainability; Design, Process, Lifetime Use and Durability – 15%
4. Socio-Economic Impact – 10%
5. Creative Use of Materials – 10%

Jury Members:

1. Arch. Mphethi Morojele (South Africa Institute of Architects - SAIA)
2. Arch. Flora Runumi (Uganda Society of Architects - USA)
3. Prof. Paul Maringa (Architectural Association of Kenya - AAK)
4. Arch. Nikos Fintikakis (International Union of Architects - UIA)

Submission Format:

- A.** Project submissions are to be a maximum total of **8No. A2 size sheets in high resolution**, in PDF or JPEG file formats. Clarity and quality of presentation, as well as completeness of requested information will be assessed at the shortlisting stage. The breakdown of the sheets is indicated in points **B to E**, below.
- B.** **1No. A2 size sheet in portrait format**, explaining the overall design concept. The drawing scale should ensure legibility of the design (in plans, sections, elevations, facades and perspectives). This is essential for the preliminary evaluation and shortlisting of submitted projects.
- C.** **A maximum of 2No. A2 size sheets** illustrating a ground floor plan (1:100) showing: topographical data, access, roadways, landscaping, walkways; and an upper level or typical level floor plan (1:100)
- D.** **A maximum of 4No. A2 size sheets** illustrating cross and longitudinal sections (part or whole) clearly indicating the levels and materials (1:100); and 2No. detailed elevations (1:100).
- E.** **1No. A2 size sheets** of 3D visualizations illustrating interiors or exteriors of the building (can be perspectives, isometric, axonometric, sectional perspectives, or other).
- F.** All drawings are to include annotated description of the key design elements and/or principles employed.
- G.** All drawings to be compiled in **1No. hi-resolution PDF file** and to be uploaded on the link accompanying these requirements.
- H.** **Submission Deadline: 13th March 2026.**
- I.** **Submission Fees: KES 5,500/-** per project. Payment to be made to the AAK M-PESA Paybill: **988567**; Account: **AWARDS.**
- J.** Participating organisations will be awarded **one (1) dinner ticket** to the Awards Ceremony, on **26th March 2026** to be held at Emara Ole Sereni Hotel (off Mombasa Road).

Submission Portal: [AAK BASCO DURACOAT AWARDS OF EXCELLENCE – REGISTRATION FORM](#)

Project Architect to complete project team details.

Other Terms and Conditions

Consent: By submitting materials for the AAK Duracoat Awards of Excellence in Architecture, entrants are giving AAK permission to store and publish all images and information for any promotional, CPD and educational use and for the records, both physical and on the web. It is the responsibility of entrants to obtain all necessary consents from other stakeholders to the projects, including project owners prior to submitting entries.

Exhibition: All projects submitted will be shown to the public at an exhibition at the ADD Building, University of Nairobi, Dinner Venue or such other places as the planning team deems fit.



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